

Korea Internet

Korea E-commerce: Seeing is believing 2026... Online grocery shopping reality check



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What began as a simple consumer task - purchasing yogurt and a BTS collaboration ramen for a short stay in Korea - quickly evolved into a grounded comparison of four major grocery platforms: Coupang, Naver Shopping with Kurly, SSG.com, and Baemin B-Mart. This exercise highlights a key reality for investors: the competitive landscape in quick commerce is not determined solely by headline pricing, but by the interplay of pricing structure, delivery thresholds, and assortment availability in real consumer scenarios.

Coupang - Lowest price, but structural friction. Coupang emerges as the clear leader on absolute pricing. However, this leadership is partially offset by structural friction embedded in its delivery system. Specifically, Rocket Fresh requires a KRW 15,000 minimum based on discounted prices rather than listing prices, and products outside the Fresh category do not contribute to this threshold. In practice, this creates inefficiencies in basket construction: in this case, the ramen was only available under Rocket delivery, meaning it could not be combined with Fresh items to meet the free delivery requirement. While Coupang wins on price, category segmentation introduces meaningful limitations to real-world usability.

Naver and Kurly - Easier threshold, hidden advantage. In contrast, Naver Shopping and Kurly benefit from a more consumer-friendly threshold mechanism. Their free delivery requirements are based on listing prices rather than post-discount payment amounts, making it materially easier for users to qualify for free shipping. This seemingly subtle distinction has meaningful implications. When the threshold is met, the effective total cost becomes competitive with Coupang, particularly for multi-item baskets - further supported by 3%+ cash rewards from Naver Shopping membership. As such, their advantage lies less in headline pricing and more in structural flexibility, enabling smoother basket formation and fewer forced purchasing decisions.

SSG.com - Assortment gap still a constraint. SSG.com, on the other hand, illustrates the continued importance of assortment depth in online grocery. The absence of the specific Greek yogurt brand sought in this case highlights a broader issue: online SKU availability remains narrower than offline equivalents. This gap directly constrains demand capture, regardless of pricing or delivery competitiveness. However, the limitation appears at least partially linked to regulatory constraints around online fulfillment from offline stores. Should policies evolve to enable broader integration - such as expanded dawn delivery from physical retail locations - SSG.com's assortment gap could narrow.

Baemin B-Mart - Speed over everything, at a price. Baemin's B-Mart reflects a distinctly different strategic positioning. Bamin is clearly driving quick commerce, prioritizing speed and convenience. While the platform did carry the specific items required, its pricing was significantly higher than competitors, and overall SKU breadth remained limited. The result is a sharply defined but narrow use case: B-Mart is best suited for urgent, short-window delivery needs within 1-2 hours, rather than routine grocery shopping. Its value proposition is therefore situational, with premium pricing acting as a barrier to broader adoption despite strong last-mile capabilities.

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	22 Jun 2026		Price Target	TTM Rel. Perf.	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
		Cur	Closing Price			Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
CPNG (Coupang)	U	USD	17.31	12.00	(64.6)%	USD	0.10	(0.37)	0.21	174.6	(47.2)	82.2
035420.KS (Naver)	O	KRW	222,500	330,000	(72.7)%	KRW	13,065	14,089	15,745	17.0	15.8	14.1
SPX			7,472.79									
ASIAX			2,072.31									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We have **Outperform** rating on **Naver**; **Underperform** rating on **Coupang**.

Unlike market concerns that Naver's shift toward the Naver Neocloud business will consume its resources, the company appears to be continuing its push in commerce. As a meaningful portion of Naver's operating cash flow is generated from digital search advertising and commerce ad (KRW 3 trillion in 2025), it is likely to sustain investment in its commerce segment to support future initiatives. At the same time, given that industry-wide commerce margins are largely determined by competitive intensity, we believe ongoing price competition may put pressure on both Naver Platform margins and Coupang's Product Commerce margins.

DETAILS

EXHIBIT 1: **Coupage leads on absolute pricing, but its KRW 15,000 Fresh-only threshold and inability to combine Rocket items create basket inefficiencies that limit real-world usability.**

... and products outside the Fresh category do not contribute to this threshold

Rocket Fresh requires a KRW 15,000 minimum based on discounted prices rather than listing prices

Disclaimer: This case is intended to illustrate a specific consumer experience and does not represent all shopping scenarios; actual pricing, discounts, assortment, and delivery conditions may vary depending on timing, location, and platform-specific factors.

Source: Company application, Bernstein analysis.

EXHIBIT 2: **With a 30% membership coupon on June 22, the deal on Naver/Kurly looks attractive, supported by a more favorable free shipping threshold.**

30% discount coupon for Naver shopping members

Free shipping threshold: 20,000 KRW

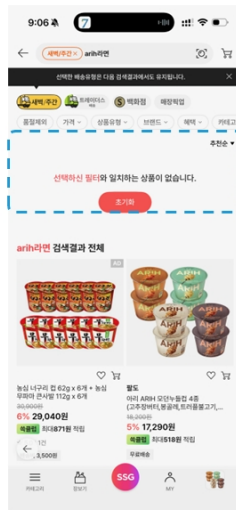
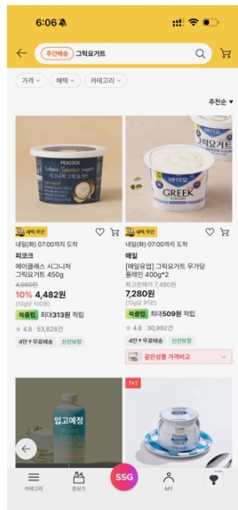
Final price: 15,840 KRW with 3% cash reward point

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Source: Company application, Bernstein analysis.

EXHIBIT 3: SSG.com underscores an assortment constraint - limited SKU availability, driven partly by offline-to-online fulfillment restrictions, caps demand capture today but could improve if regulatory integration evolves.

SSG.COM emartmall



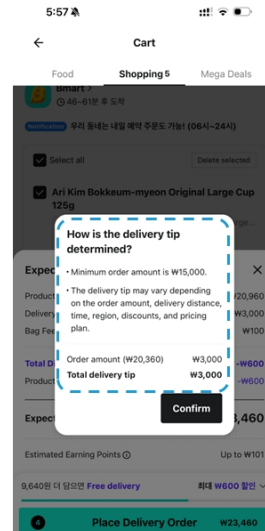
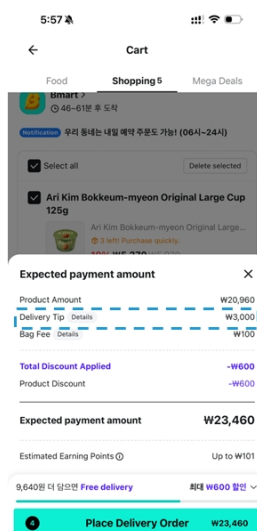
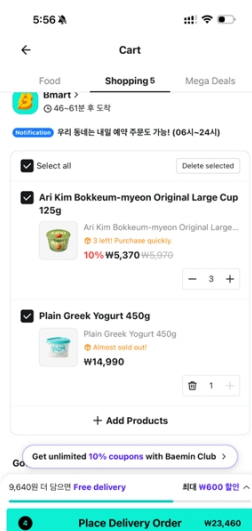
The absence of the specific Greek yogurt brand sought in this case highlights a broader issue for SSG.com: online SKU availability remains narrower than offline equivalents.

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Source: Company application, Bernstein analysis.

EXHIBIT 4: Baemin B-Mart prioritizes ultra-fast delivery with adequate item availability, but higher pricing and limited assortment confine its value to urgent, short-window needs rather than everyday grocery shopping.

BAEMIN



The high free delivery threshold on Baemin reduces overall cost competitiveness.

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Source: Company application, Bernstein analysis.

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VALUATION METHODOLOGY**Coupang Inc**

We have valued Coupang at a price target of USD 12 based on a DCF valuation method, implying one year forward PER of 45x (Q2 2027-Q1 2028). (DCF assumptions: WACC=12%, Terminal growth rate: 2%; Risk-Free Rate of Return (Rf) = 3.6%, Market Risk Premium (Rm - Rf) = 17%, Beta = 0.5).

Naver Corporation

We have valued Naver at a price target of KRW 330,000 based on a DCF valuation method, implying one year forward PER of 20x (Q2 2027-Q1 2028). (DCF assumptions: WACC=12%, Terminal growth rate: 2%; Risk-Free Rate of Return (Rf) = 3.6%, Market Risk Premium (Rm - Rf) = 17%, Beta = 0.5).

RISKS**Coupang Inc**

Upside risk: Stronger-than-expected top-line growth; end of investment cycle in overseas markets and market share gains; resolution of regulatory risk overhang issues.

Naver Corporation

Downside risk: Weaker-than-expected e-commerce GMV growth; faster-than-expected user engagement decline in the search domain; additional investment in non-core business; government disapproval of the stock swap with Dunamu.

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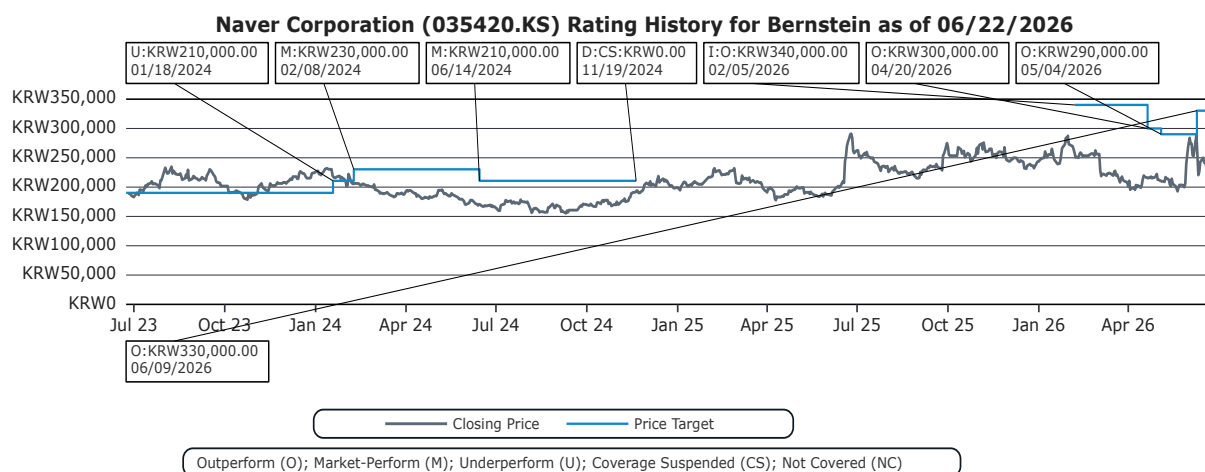
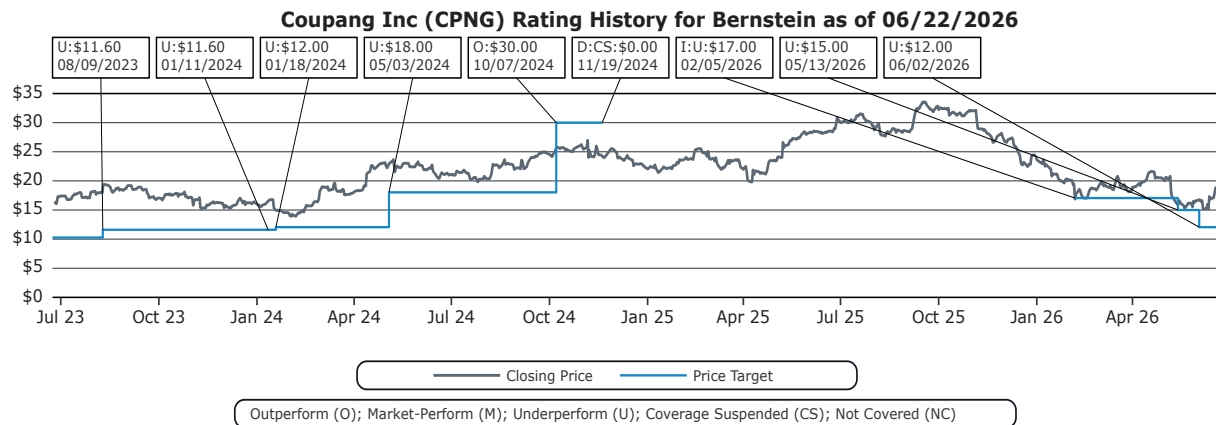
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